



Te Tāhuhu o
te Mātauranga
Ministry of Education

Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

Pathways from Year 11 – four years after starting

By the end of 2024, 80.1% of the learner cohort entering Year 11 in 2021 had attained a Level 2 certificate or above after four years

Indicator description

This indicator tracks learners from the start of Year 11 and reports on the proportion who have attained a Level 2 certificate or above four years after starting Year 11.

In this report, the spotlight is primarily on attainment outcomes four years after starting Year 11. An indicator report on attainment outcomes two years after starting Year 11 is covered separately, see: [Pathways from Year 11 – two years after starting](#).

Why this is important

A Level 2 certificate opens doors to further education, training, or entry into the labour-market. Most learners will attain a National Certificate of Educational Achievement (NCEA)¹ Level 2 which is designed to provide the basic knowledge and skills required for employment.

Achieving a Level 2 certificate increases choice and is associated with higher future earnings. Modelling done by the Ministry in 2024 of earnings at age 30 showed income premiums for those attaining a L2 qualification, L3 qualification or for meeting the requirements for University Entrance (UE)². These were around \$10,000 higher for learners with a Level 2 or Level 3 qualification and \$23,000 higher for learners with UE compared to those with no qualifications. The findings from the modelling were also consistent with other Ministry research showing adults with no qualifications earned almost 20% less in weekly income and around 12% less in hourly earnings than those with school qualifications³.

¹ For more information about NCEA see [About NCEA - NZQA](#)

² For more information see [Information Update: Influence of Student Characteristics, Experiences, and Outcomes on Income at Age 30](#), proactively released under the Official Information Act (METIS no 1350376). Note four separate documents were proactively released together. Refer to document where METIS no 1350376 is referenced.

³ For more information, see [Education, income and earnings – with updates for 2020](#)

Latest data

The latest data is for learners who attained a Level 2 certificate or above by the end of 2024. Data for the two-year time point is available for 2009-2023 cohorts. Data for the four-year time point is available for 2009-2021 cohorts.

How we are going

National attainment overall

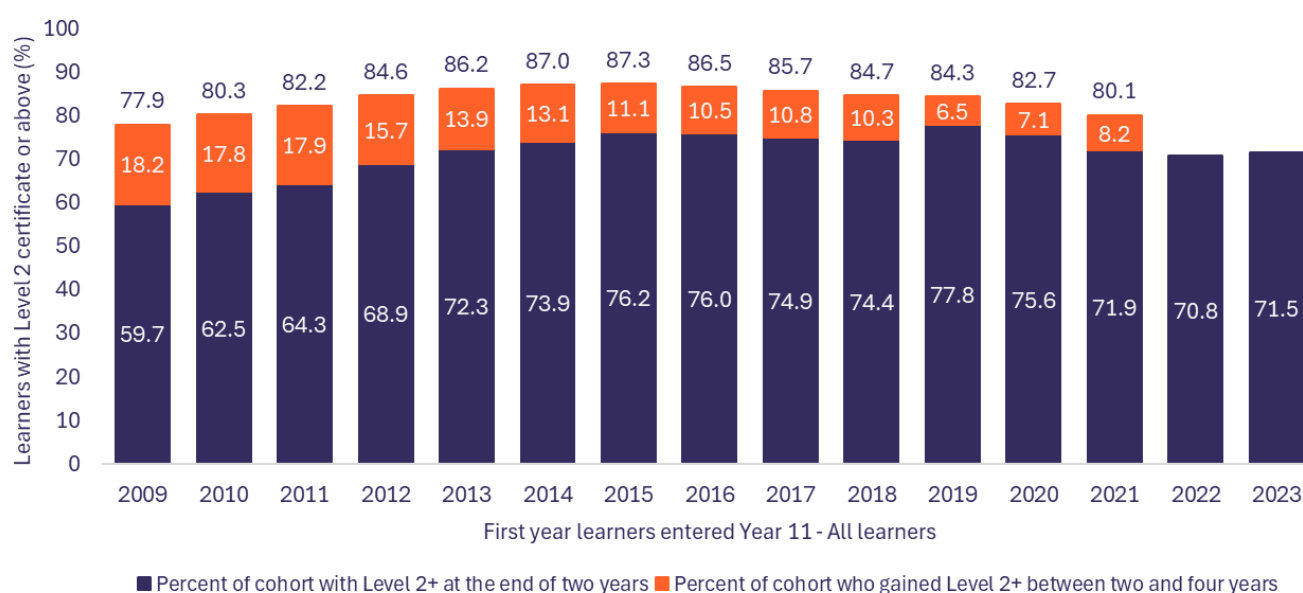
Figure 1 shows that since 2009, most learners have attained a Level 2 certificate or above two years after starting Year 11. For learners who entered Year 11 for the first time in 2023, 71.5% of this cohort attained a Level 2 certificate or above two years after starting Year 11. This was an increase of 0.7 percentage points compared with the 2022 cohort (70.8%), reversing a downward trend since 2019 (84.3%), when the rate was at its highest.

Attainment after four years rose steadily from 77.9% for the 2009 cohort to a high of 87.3% for the 2015 cohort. This was mainly driven by increases in learners completing a Level 2 certificate or above within two years of starting Year 11. Attainment rates for the four-year time point remained relatively high and were above 84.0% until 2019 before declining to 80.1% for 2021 cohort.

For the cohort entering Year 11 in 2021, the proportion of learners who attained a Level 2 certificate or above four years after starting Year 11 decreased by 2.6 percentage points compared with the 2020 cohort (82.7%), continuing the downward trend since the 2015 cohort (87.3%), when attainment peaked.

The proportion of learners gaining a Level 2 certificate or above between two and four years after starting Year 11 has decreased over time as more learners attained by the end of two years. For the cohort who started Year 11 in 2009, 18.2% gained a Level 2 or above between two and four years after starting Year 11. This decreased to 8.2% for learners who entered Year 11 in 2021.

Figure 1: Attainment rates for Level 2 certificate or above, 2009-2023 cohorts



Settings where a Level 2 certificate or above is attained

Most learners attain a Level 2 certificate or above in school, while a small proportion attain it in a tertiary setting (either a provider-based or workplace-based setting).

For the 2021 cohort, among those who attained a Level 2 certificate or above four years after starting Year 11, 96.3% (47,183 learners) attained it at school and 3.7% attained it through a tertiary setting (1,655 learners in a provider-based setting and 145 learners in a workplace-based setting).

First Level 2 certificate or above

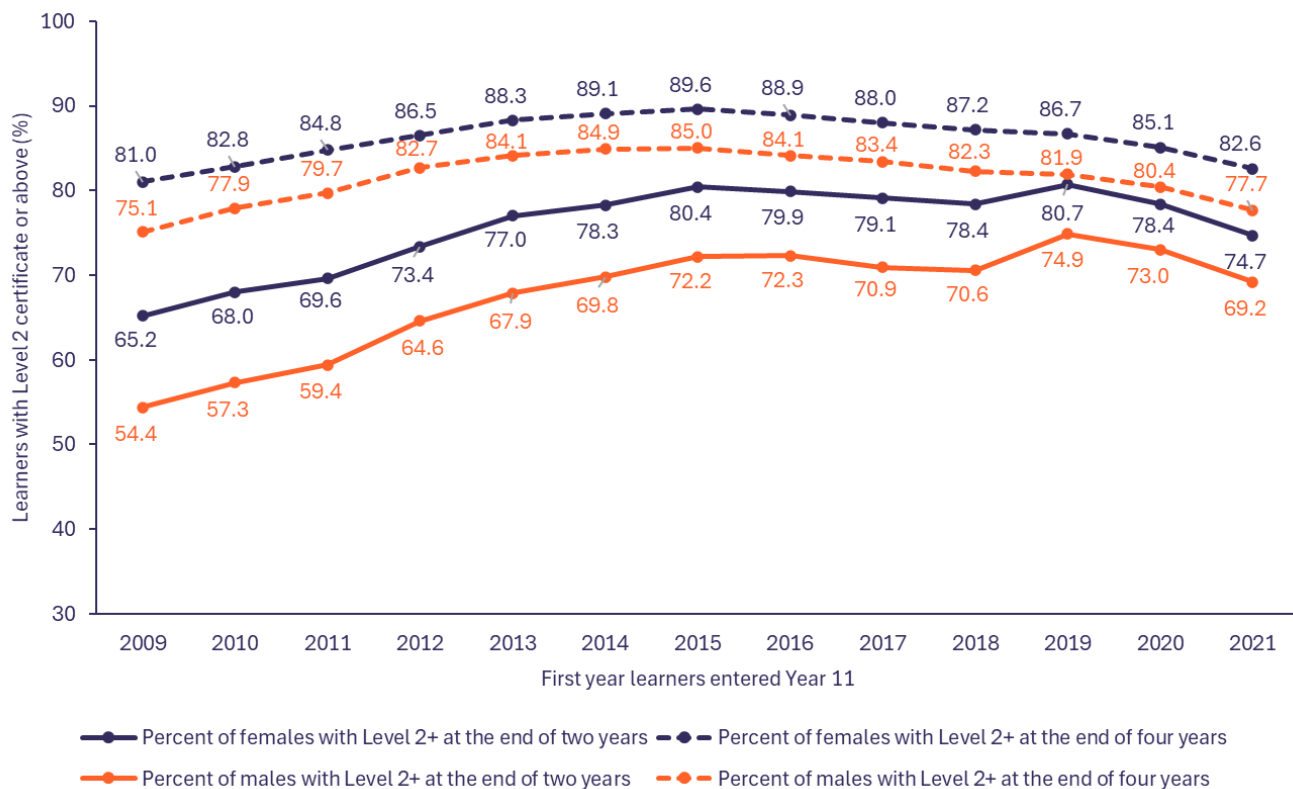
For learners who attained a Level 2 certificate or above (80.1% of learners who started Year 11 in 2021), NCEA Level 2 was the most common way for the requirement to be met among learners. For the 2021 cohort, 91.7% of learners with a Level 2 certificate or above first met the requirement through the attainment of NCEA Level 2 within four years after starting Year 11 and 8.3% met the requirement via a different pathway.

Attainment by gender

More female learners attained a Level 2 certificate or above, compared to male learners (see Figure 2).

For the 2021 cohort, 82.6% of females and 77.7% of males had a Level 2 certificate or above four years after starting Year 11. Compared with the 2020 cohort, this was a decrease of 2.5 percentage points for females and 2.7 percentage points for males. The gender gap for the 2021 cohort was 4.9 percentage points, up from 4.7 percentage points for the 2020 cohort.

Figure 2: Proportion of learners with a Level 2 certificate or above, by gender, 2009-2021 cohorts

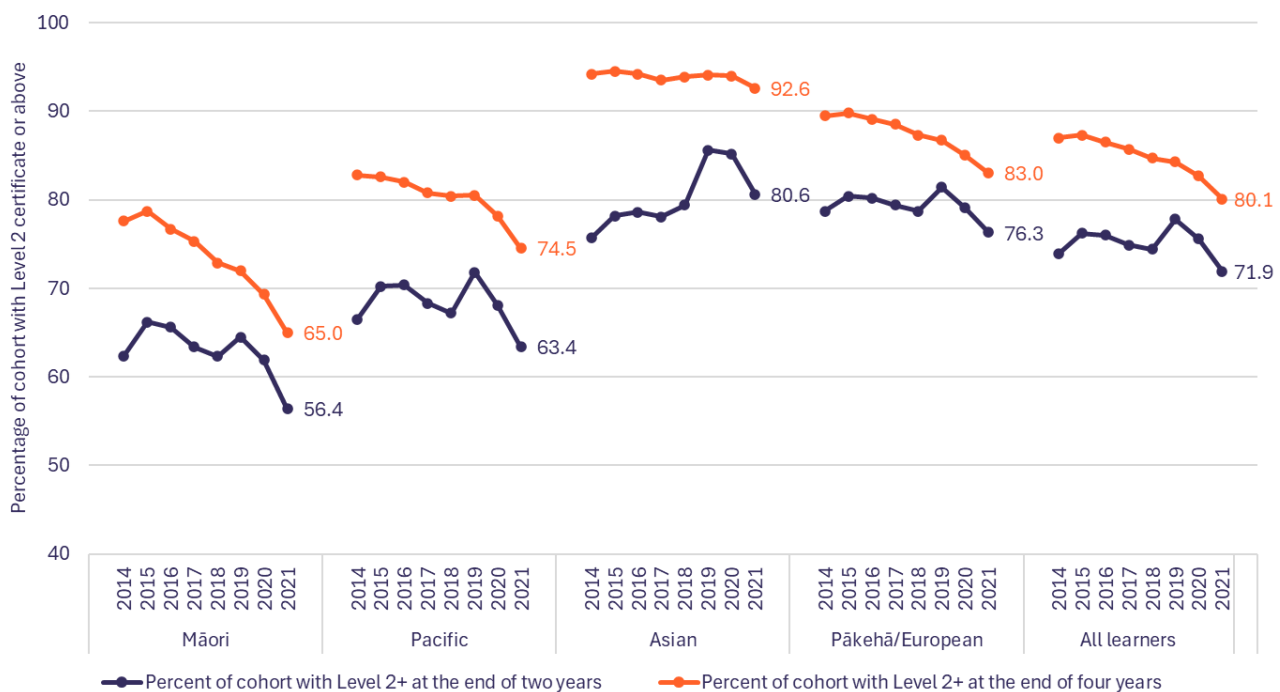


Attainment by ethnicity⁴

Figure 3 below shows that compared to the national average, a higher proportion of Asian and European/Pākehā learners attained a Level 2 certificate or above, while attainment rates for Māori and Pacific learners were lower. This pattern has remained consistent since 2016 and highlights the attainment gap between ethnic groups.

Among learners who entered Year 11 for the first time in 2021, 65.0% of Māori, 74.5% of Pacific, 92.6% of Asian, and 83.0% of European/Pākehā learners attained a Level 2 certificate or above four years after starting Year 11. Compared with the 2020 cohort, this was a decrease of 4.3 percentage points for Māori, 3.7 percentage points for Pacific, 1.8 percentage points for Asian and 2.0 percentage points for European/Pākehā learners.

Figure 3: Percentage of learners with a Level 2 certificate or above two and four years after starting Year 11, by ethnicity, 2014-2021 cohorts



Ākonga Māori and language of learning⁵

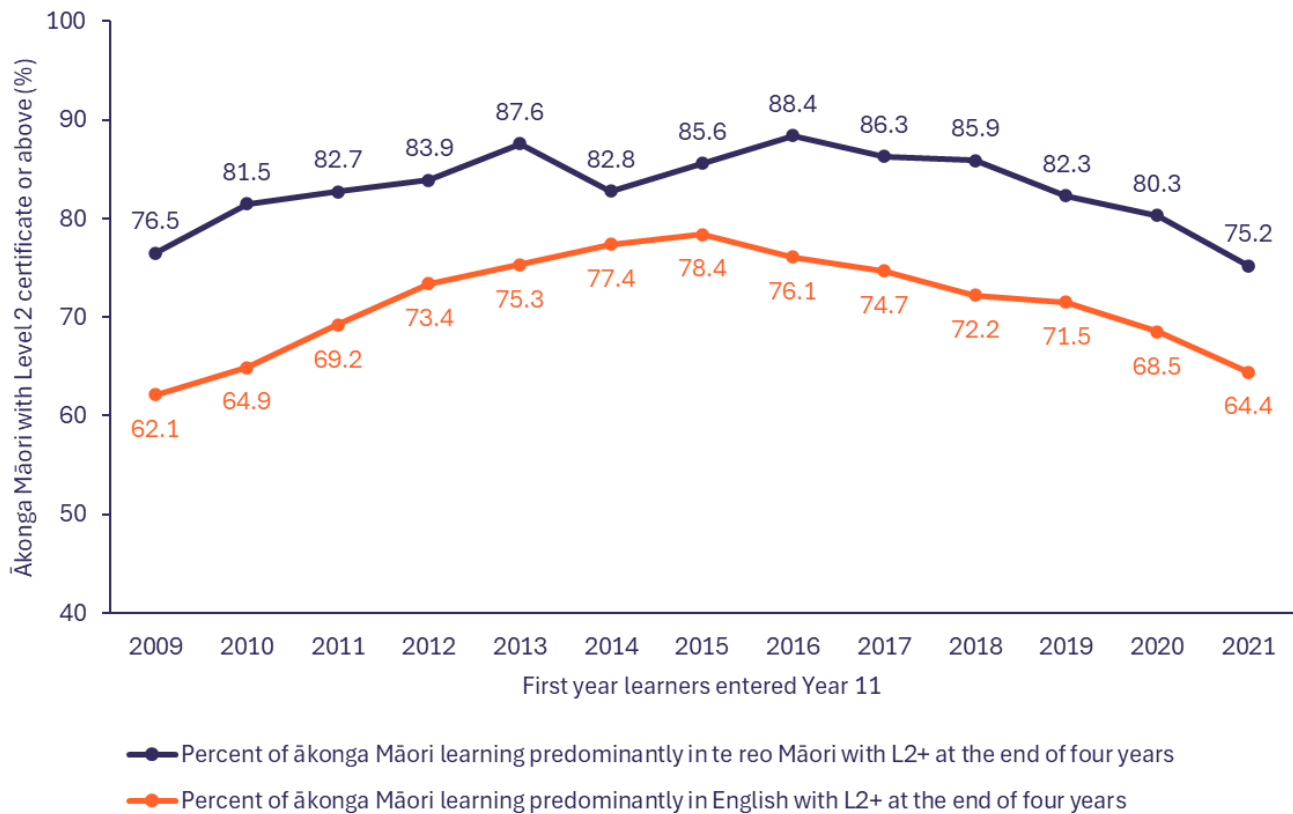
Figure 4 below shows that by both two and four years after starting Year 11, a higher proportion of ākonga Māori learning predominantly in te reo Māori have attained a Level 2 certificate or above compared to ākonga Māori learning predominantly in English. This pattern has been consistent since 2009, however the gap between these two groups has narrowed over time.

⁴ Total response ethnicity counts students who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.

⁵ Māori Language Learning describes the percentage of time in which Māori language is spoken in the classroom. The predominant language of learning is the one that learners are learning in at least 51% of the time.

For learners who entered Year 11 in 2021, 75.2% of ākonga Māori learning predominantly in te reo Māori had attained a Level 2 certificate or above after four years compared to 64.4% of ākonga Māori learning predominantly in English. This was a decrease of 5.1 and 4.1 percentage points respectively, from the 2020 cohort. Attainment rates for both groups have been declining year-on-year since 2017.

Figure 4: Proportion of ākonga Māori with Level 2 certificate or above after four years, by language of learning, 2009-2021 cohorts



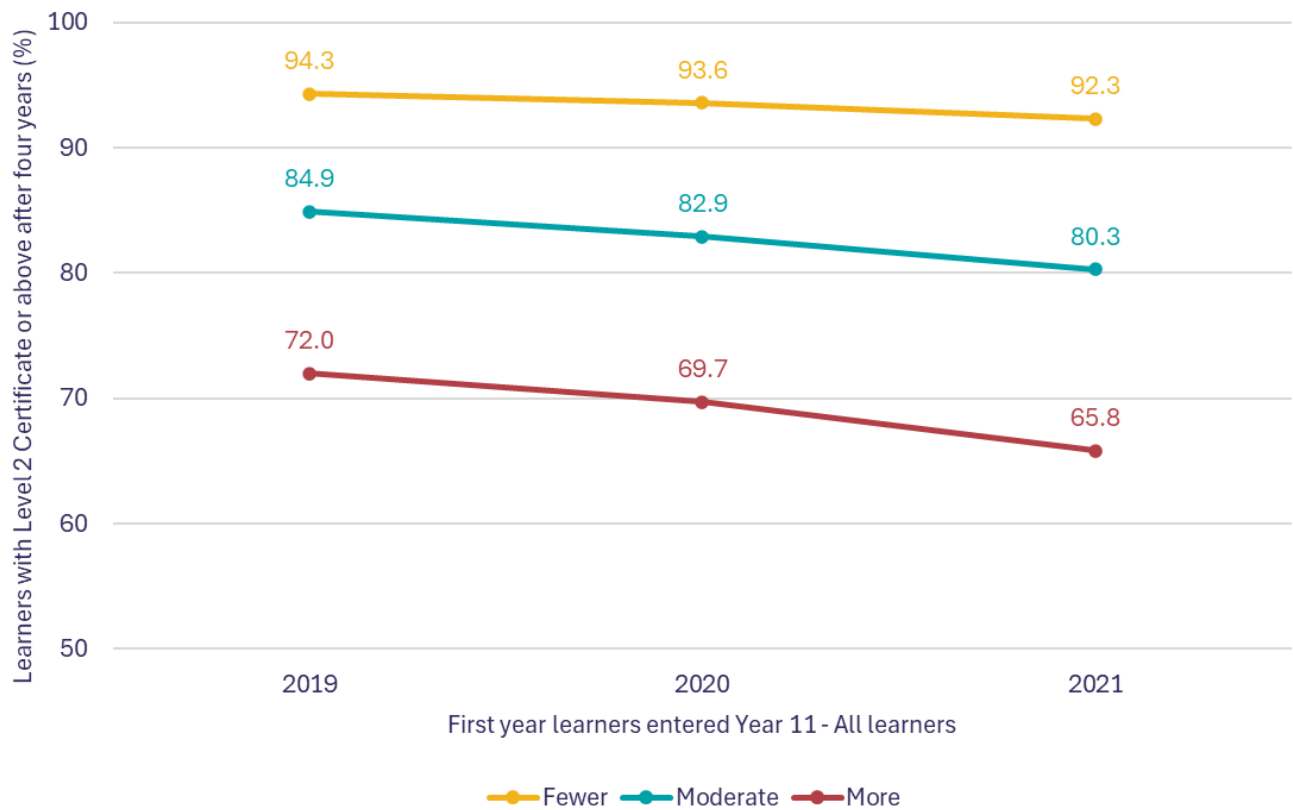
Attainment by socioeconomic status

Learners who experience fewer socioeconomic barriers to achievement are more likely to attain a Level 2 certificate or above. As shown in Figure 5 below, schools where learners had fewer socioeconomic barriers to achievement were more likely to have a higher proportion of learners who attained a Level 2 certificate or above at the end of four years compared to schools where learners had moderate to more socioeconomic barriers.

For the 2021 cohort, 92.3% of learners from schools where learners had fewer barriers attained a Level 2 certificate or above four years after starting Year 11 compared to 80.3% of learners from schools where learners had moderate barriers and 65.8% of learners from schools where learners had more barriers. Compared with the 2020 cohort, these were decreases of 1.3, 2.6, and 3.9 percentage points respectively.

The attainment gap between schools where learners had fewer barriers and more barriers was 26.5 percentage points for the 2021 cohort, an increase from 23.9 percentage points for the 2020 cohort.

Figure 5: Percentage of learners with a Level 2 certificate or above after four years, by school equity index groups, 2019-2021 cohorts



Technical notes and definitions

Attainment

This measure looks at whether learners have attained a Level 2 certificate or above. This includes attainment of NCEA Level 2 or Level 3 and attainment from alternative examinations-based systems offered in New Zealand schools including Cambridge Examinations and International Baccalaureate. It also includes other qualifications on the New Zealand Qualifications and Credentials Framework attained in school or tertiary settings at Level 2 or above which require successful completion of at least half a year at Level 3 in school, or one semester or more at Level 2 or higher in tertiary.

Cohort of learners

A learner's entry into Year 11 is identified from enrolment data held by the Ministry of Education (the Ministry) and the New Zealand Qualifications Authority (NZQA). This is used to identify cohorts of learners based on the year they entered Year 11. For example, the 2023 cohort in this report is the group of learners who started Year 11 in 2023.

Time points

The percentage of each cohort of learners who have attained a Level 2 certificate or above is examined at two time points:

- **Two years after starting Year 11:** For most learners NCEA Level 2 will be their first qualification at Level 2 or above. This has been chosen because the theoretical timeframe for completion of NCEA Level 2 is two years. By the end of Year 12 most learners would have attained NCEA Level 2.
- **Four years after starting Year 11:** Some learners will complete a Level 2 certificate in a subsequent year, either at school or in a tertiary setting (provider-based or work-based). The second time point, four years after starting Year 11 (theoretical timeframe plus two years), reflects this.

Projection beyond these two time points is not covered in this report because as time passes the value of a Level 2 certificate is often superseded by the attainment of higher qualifications or work experience.

Other information

This indicator replaces statistics previously reported for the attainment of NCEA Level 2 or above by 18-year-olds. The attainment rate at the end of four years after starting Year 11 is comparable with attainment at 18-years-old.

The data from this indicator is also used to complete the Education at a Glance survey on completion of upper secondary education every three years. Data from these cohorts will be included in analysis along with other countries' data in the Education at a Glance | OECD Indicators report for 2026⁶.

⁶ This analysis was last published by the OECD in Education at a Glance 2023 in Chapter B3 - [Indicator B3 'Who is expected to complete upper secondary education?'](#) (OECD 2023).

NZQA publishes an analysis of attainment of NCEA and UE by a Tracked Year 11 cohort in its annual report on [NCEA, UE and New Zealand Scholarship](#). The population for the Ministry Year 11 cohort indicator report is based on a similar (but not the same) population to the one used by NZQA.

- The attainment reported by the Ministry is the attainment of Level 2 certificate or above, which includes the attainment of NCEA and UE. It also includes attainment from other qualifications on the New Zealand Qualifications and Credentials Framework attained in school and tertiary settings, as well as attainment from alternative examinations-based systems offered in New Zealand schools including Cambridge and International Baccalaureate examinations.
- The attainment reported by NZQA is focused on NCEA and University Entrance Award and is limited to attainment in school-based enrolments.

Pathways to a Level 2 certificate or above

National Certificate of Educational Achievement

New Zealand schooling provides a general programme that prepares learners for diverse pathways. NCEA is the main nationally recognised qualification offered in upper-secondary schooling. In Years 11-13, learners work towards NCEA at Levels 1, 2, and 3.

By design, NCEA is highly inclusive, flexible, and accessible, premising New Zealand's stance that the education journey for each learner is different and individualised. Other countries in the OECD may offer both a general track (for those deemed more academically able) and a vocational track in upper-secondary, with learners branching off and following one of these two tracks. Most learners will achieve NCEA Level 2 while they are still at school.

Although NCEA is offered as a general programme, some aspects of vocational learning and training are available and can be accessed by learners in several ways, for example, through a Vocational Pathways Award.⁷ Learners who have attained NCEA Level 2 and have met the requirements for one of six industries for a Vocational Pathways Award will have their NCEA Level 2 qualification endorsed with that Vocational Pathways Award(s). These awards recognise learners who have achieved a significant set of NCEA Level 2 standards that align with the knowledge and skills that employers are looking for in a particular pathway.

Secondary-tertiary pathways

In some instances, learners in Years 11-13 can also participate in vocational education through a dual pathway system through secondary-tertiary programmes, either through Trades Academies or Services Academies. These academies are partnerships between schools, industry training organisations (including tertiary providers), and employers; and facilitate a hybrid learning environment (with some of the learning taking place at school and some with industry training organisations). The aim of these academies is to support learners to achieve at a minimum of NCEA Level 2, remain engaged with learning, and to enable successful transition into higher education, vocational training, and employment.

⁷ Vocational Pathways Awards are offered in six broad industries: Creative Industries, Primary Industries, Service Industries, Social and Community Services, Construction and Infrastructure, Manufacturing and Technology.

Youth Guarantee

For learners who leave school with less than Level 2 certificate, the Youth Guarantee scheme (available to young people aged between 16 and 24) provides fees-free tertiary study at Levels 1-3. This supports young people to progress to higher-level education or employment. This initiative provides another pathway for young people to attain NCEA Level 2 or a range of certificates at Level 2 or above.

Higher qualifications

Some learners bypass a Level 2 certificate and complete a higher-level qualification altogether either at school or in a tertiary setting as their first certificate at Level 2 or above. These include NCEA Level 3 or equivalent, University Entrance, Level 4 certificates, and Level 5-7 diplomas.

School equity index

From 2023, School Equity Index replaced School Decile as the method determining additional funding for schools to overcome socioeconomic disadvantages that impact learner achievement.

The Ministry has developed a new method of reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics called School Equity Index Bands and Groups. These categories estimate the extent to which, on average, learners at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement.

School Equity Index Bands and Groups are derived from the Schooling Equity Index. There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their Equity Index number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as illustrated below. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's Education Counts website [here](#).

Schooling Equity Index Number:



School Equity Index Band:

Fewest	Few	Below Average	Average	Above Average	Many	Most

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

School Equity Index Group:

Fewer	Moderate	More

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

Where to find out more

Please visit our Education Counts webpage for more information about learner achievement and other education statistics.

- [School leavers' attainment](#)
- [Tertiary achievement and attainment](#)

References

- Ministry of Education. (2024). [Indicator: Vocational Pathways Awards \(2024\)](#)
- Ministry of Education. (2026). [NCEA tertiary training for Kiwi youth. Without Fees](#)
- Ministry of Education (2025). [Information Update: Influence of Student Characteristics, Experiences and Outcomes on Income at Age 30](#) (METIS no. 1350376)
- New Zealand Qualifications Authority. (2026). [Secondary school statistics](#)
- OECD. (2023). [Indicator B3. Who is expected to complete upper secondary education?](#) in [Education at a Glance 2023: OECD indicators](#)
- Scott, D. Ministry of Education (2021). [Education, income and earnings – with updates for 2020](#)
- Tertiary Education Commission. (2026). [Youth Guarantee Fund](#)